DADDY NO. 1



Who is Bihar's Daddy No. 1? Ask **Prashant Kishor**, and he'll pick **Lalu Prasad Yadav** every time. Not because PK is moonlighting for the RJD, but because, by his own admission, he's an admirer of Laluji's tireless efforts to see son Tejashwi crowned as Bihar CM. At every Jan Suraj rally, Kishor tells his audience that they should learn from Laluji and think about the future of their own children. The back-handed compliment aside, what PK is saying is that voters should think hard about who they're plumping for in the coming election.

A Quiet Reboot?



PDP chief **Mehbooba Mufti** met J&K Lt Governor **Manoj Sinha** in Srinagar on June 2, their first encounter since the abrogation of Article 370 in 2019. Mufti, a sharp critic of the L-G's decisions, especially the firing of public employees, has sought to position her party as an alternative to the NC's "faltering governance" model. So, is this the first sign of a rapprochement and a possible shift in the power levers? But then her PDP hardly has enough MLAs to make a dent.

NEW FLIGHT PATH



In politics, there are no permanent enemies. Congress rivals in Rajasthan **Sachin Pilot** and Ashok Gehlot had a 'reunion' of sorts recently when the former visited to invite him for an event marking father and former Union minister Rajesh Pilot's 25th death anniversary. The gesture is seen as a softening of the hard stand Pilot had taken against the three-time CM. The buzz is that with the courtesy call, and Gehlot's warm reception, Pilot is smoothing the runway for a possible landing as PCC chief next year.

Kaushik Deka with Avaneesh Misra, Avishek G. Dastidar, Amitabh Srivastava, Kaleem Geelani and Rohit Parihar

HEALTH WATCH

The Ketamine Cacophony

By **Sonali Acharjee**

Ketamine is not a new drug. But since the accusations made by US President Donald Trump that Elon Musk allegedly uses it to treat depression, the drug has been edging into mainstream view. Ketamine has been used widely to manage pain and anesthesia during surgical procedures. For its hallucinogenic effects, it is also used as a party drug, going by the name of 'Special K'. In India, ketamine is categorised as a Schedule III controlled substance but outside of hospitals it is relatively unknown.



SHUTTERSTOCK

A study published in the National Library of Medicine found that it does indeed help ease depressive symptoms and anxiety. Last year, the Sion Hospital in Mumbai found that a mix of 2 ml ketamine in 300 ml orange juice helped counter suicidal thoughts in a patient. But that doesn't mean it is good or safe to take without guidance.

Cases of dependency, withdrawal symptoms, and, in some patients, increased anxiety have been reported. Some 55 per cent of people who have tried at-home ketamine therapy reported either accidentally or intentionally using more than the recommended dose, says a 2023 survey by mental-health company All Points North. Short-term use comes with risks as well—high BP, nausea and hallucinations at night. Long-term chronic use can cause bladder, liver and urinary tract disorders. Best then, to avoid its use.